

EXPECTING AN ENCORE Chhattisgarh CM Bhupesh Baghel at a government event in Bijapur, Sept. 18

BATTLE FOR CHHATTISGARH

IT ISN'T AN OPEN AND SHUT CASE

By Rahul Noronha

With the assembly election in Chhattisgarh just around two months away, there has been a noticeable shift in how the contest is being perceived. With each passing day, political observers are convinced that it won't be a one-sided contest like in 2018—when the ruling Congress unequivocally trumped the BJP. Instead, they are anticipating a return to the 2003, 2008 and 2013 polls that went down to the wire. Most importantly, below the broad bipolarity at the top that defines Chhattisgarh politics, there are smaller players who make the base rather more mobile than it appears. The third front, which secured an impressive 12 per cent of the vote share in 2018, might go back to its usual share of 5-7 per cent. In 2018, the Congress had won its most comprehensive electoral victory in the state, getting 68 out of 90 seats. In the past five years, the party has also won every bypoll here, taking its tally to 71. The BJP won a mere 15 seats in 2018 and its numbers have since shrunk to 14. But it retains a strong state organisation, and even a slight rebalancing in local voting patterns owing to new players could change the overall picture.

The Bhupesh Baghel government is banking on its work in the rural and farm sectors. The payment of bonus on procured paddy is expected to reap rich dividends in the state's prosperous central region, which accounts for 60 out of 90 assembly segments. And, taking a cue from the BJP, it has also worked on its so-called 'soft Hindutva' side. It has developed, most visibly, the 'Ram Van Gaman Path'—a pilgrim-tourism trail covering Lord Ram's mythical march to Lanka. There have also been Ramayana recitation contests. The Congress regime has also promoted Chhattisgarhi identity—celebrating local language and cuisine, with a 'Chhattisgarhi Olympics' built around traditional sports thrown in for good measure. All this, the Congress hopes, will help it take the edge off the BJP's hard Hindutva, which saw communal riots erupt in Kabirdham district in 2022 and in Bemetara district in April 2023 and attacks on churches in the tribal belt.

However, the Congress does face anti-incumbency. Surveys suggest the disaffection is targeted against MLAs; CM Baghel himself remains popular. The 15 urban assembly seats here are a concern for the party because of the narrative that the government has neglected urban infrastructure. Simultaneously, the BJP seems to have recovered lost ground, buoyed by regular visits by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Amit Shah, and what seemed a lost cause is being looked upon with renewed interest. It's confident about the urban seats and is attempting to stitch up a Sahu-led OBC alliance to dent the Congress vote in central Chhattisgarh. Sahus are the state's biggest OBC community.

THE THIRD FRONT'S SHIFTING FORTUNES AND THE ARRIVAL OF NEW PARTIES HAS CHANGED THE SHAPE OF THE PIE

Parties other than the big two, like the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), have typically won 5-7 per cent of the votes individually. In 2018, the BSP had an alliance with the late Ajit Jogi's Janta Congress Chhattisgarh (JCC). The combine secured over 12 per